

PASSWITHPURPOSE

NEW
2027
FORMAT

CAMBRIDGE IGCSE • FIRST LANGUAGE ENGLISH • 0500

Paper 2

Directed Writing 2

Four complete Section A tasks for the new 2027 exam, covering the 1(a) structured question and 1(b) directed writing, with model answers for a speech, a letter, an article and a report.

- ◆ 4 full Section A tasks (160 marks)
- ◆ New 1(a) evaluation questions
- ◆ 4 annotated model answers
- ◆ Planning frame & form toolkit
- ◆ 6 original source texts
- ◆ 1(b) in all four forms
- ◆ Mark schemes & indicative content
- ◆ Evaluation phrase bank

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For exams in 2027, 2028 and 2029. Independent practice material; not produced or endorsed by Cambridge University Press & Assessment. All texts are original.

How to use this pack

From June 2027, Section A of Cambridge IGCSE First Language English (0500) Paper 2 gives candidates one or two texts (about 550–650 words in total) and two linked questions. This pack gives you four complete tasks in that format, one for each form candidates may be asked to write.

Question	What candidates do	Marks
1(a)	Short structured answers: analyse and evaluate the ideas in the text(s), including how the writer tries to influence readers	5
1(b)	Directed writing: a speech, letter, article or report of 250–350 words that uses, develops and evaluates the ideas in the text(s)	35 10 R + 25 W

The four tasks

Task 5	Exams or Coursework?	Two texts	Article
Task 6	Is Space Worth It?	One text	Speech
Task 7	A Car-Free Town Centre	Two texts	Letter
Task 8	Teenagers and Part-Time Work	One text	Report

The five-step method for 1(b)

1 Decode	Circle the form, audience, purpose and the position you will take.
2 Map	List every argument in the text(s). Mark each one: agree, disagree or “yes, but...”.
3 Evaluate	Question the evidence: Is it reliable? Is it biased? What is missing? Do the texts contradict each other?
4 Plan	Hook, three developed paragraphs drawn from the texts, a clear conclusion or call to action.
5 Write & check	250–350 words in the right form and register. Leave time to proofread.

Timed practice

Print the insert and question paper. Allow about one hour for Section A.

Teach the form

Study the model answer and its notes first, then set a different task in the same form.

Tutoring

Use Task 5 to diagnose, then work on the weakest strand: evaluation, form or accuracy.

Form toolkit & evaluation phrase bank

Form	Must include	Register
Speech	Greeting to the audience; a hook; signposting ("First... Finally..."); direct address and inclusive "we"; a memorable close and thanks	Engaging, rhetorical, suited to listeners
Letter	"Dear..."; purpose stated in the first paragraph; one main point per paragraph; polite request or call to action; "Yours sincerely/faithfully"	Formal to officials; warmer to people you know
Article	Headline (and optional subheading); an opening that grabs attention; lively paragraphs; a strong final line	Informative and lively; suited to the publication
Report	Title; "To/From" or purpose line; clear subheadings; balanced findings; numbered recommendations; conclusion	Objective, clear and formal; no emotive language

From repeating to evaluating

Repeating	"The text says visitor numbers have fallen by forty per cent."
Using	"Visitor numbers have fallen sharply, which worries the council."
Developing	"If fewer people visit, the library may struggle to justify its costs."
Evaluating	"However, opening hours were halved, so the fall may reflect closed doors rather than lost interest."

Evaluation phrase bank

Questioning evidence

- "This statistic proves less than it seems because..."
- "The writer relies on a single example..."
- "We are not told who carried out this research..."
- "This may be true for one school, but..."

Weighing arguments

- "The strongest point here is... because..."
- "This is a fair concern, but it is not a reason to..."
- "Both writers agree that...; they differ only on..."
- "A more balanced view would recognise that..."

1(b) planning frame

Form		Audience	
Purpose		My position	

Map the text(s)

Argument / idea	Text	Agree / disagree / yes, but...	Evaluation: reliable? biased? missing?

Paragraph plan

Opening / hook	
Point 1 + evaluation	
Point 2 + evaluation	
Point 3 + evaluation	
Conclusion / call to action	

Final check

☐ Correct form conventions
 ☐ Both bullets addressed
 ☐ At least two evaluative points
 ☐ Own words
 ☐ 250–350 words
 ☐ Proofread

Exams Measure the Wrong Things

Article by Dr Leila Mansour, education researcher

- 1 Every summer, millions of teenagers sit in silent halls and try to prove, in two hours, what they have learned in two years. We accept this ritual as if it were natural. It is not. It is a habit, and a harmful one.
- 2 Exams reward a narrow set of skills: memorising facts, writing quickly and performing under pressure. These matter, but they are not the skills that employers say they need most. Surveys of businesses repeatedly put teamwork, creativity, communication and the ability to research independently at the top of their lists. None of these can be properly tested by a student alone at a desk with a clock ticking.
- 3 Exams are also unfair. A student who is ill, bereaved or simply anxious on one particular morning can see years of work undone in an afternoon. Research on exam anxiety suggests that a significant minority of students perform well below their ability under timed conditions. Is it right that a single bad day should decide a young person's future?
- 4 Coursework offers a better way. Assessed over months, it rewards consistent effort, gives students time to draft and improve, and allows them to show what they can do with real projects: an investigation, a portfolio, a presentation. In countries where continuous assessment is common, students report lower stress and teachers report deeper learning. Coursework also mirrors the way adults actually work: few jobs require anyone to write an essay in silence, from memory, in ninety minutes.
- 5 Critics worry about cheating, and it is true that coursework must be carefully supervised. But the answer to that problem is better supervision, not a return to a system that measures memory rather than understanding.
- 6 It is time to put down the pens, open the doors of the exam hall and let students show us what they really know.

In Defence of the Exam Hall

Blog post by Priyanka Nair, sixth-form student

- 1 I have sat more exams than I can count, and I have hated almost all of them. But when people suggest scrapping them, I find myself, to my own surprise, on the side of the exam hall.
- 2 The reason is fairness. In an exam, everyone sits the same paper, at the same time, under the same conditions. Nobody's parents can help. Nobody can pay a tutor to 'improve' their answers. Nobody can copy a model essay from the internet. With coursework, I have watched classmates hand in work that was suspiciously polished, and I have watched students whose parents could not help them fall behind. Coursework does not remove inequality; it hides it.
- 3 Exams also teach something valuable: how to perform when it matters. Life is full of moments like that – job interviews, driving tests, presentations to a client. Learning to prepare, stay calm and think clearly under pressure is not a flaw in the system. It is one of the most useful things school can teach. A friend of mine who froze in her first mock learned to plan her time and breathe; by the final exam, she was the calmest person in the room.
- 4 And coursework is not the stress-free paradise its supporters imagine. At my school, coursework deadlines stretch across the whole year, so there is never a moment to relax. My friends and I often feel we are sitting one long exam that never ends.
- 5 That does not mean exams are perfect. Students who are ill should have better options to resit quickly, and exams could test more than memory. But the solution is to write better exams, not to abandon them.
- 6 The exam hall is uncomfortable. It is also one of the few places where everybody is treated exactly the same.

Paper 2 Section A • Task 5: Exams or Coursework?

Section A • 40 marks • about 1 hour. Read both texts in the insert (about 590 words), then answer Question 1(a) and Question 1(b). Suggested timing: read and answer 1(a) 15 min • plan 1(b) 8 min • write 1(b) 35 min • check 2 min.

Question 1(a) 5 marks

- (i) Explain how the writer of Text 1 tries to persuade readers that exams are unfair. Refer to **two** examples from the text. [3]
- (ii) How convincing is the claim in Text 2 that coursework “does not remove inequality; it hides it”? Give reasons for your answer. [2]

Question 1(b) 35 marks

Your school is reviewing whether to replace some end-of-year exams with coursework. [35]

Write an article for the school website.

In your article you should:

- evaluate the views given in both texts
- give your own view, with reasons, on the best way to assess students.

Base your article on what you have read in both texts, but be careful to use your own words.

Address both bullet points. Write about **250 to 350 words**. Up to 10 marks are available for the content of your answer and up to 25 marks for the quality of your writing.

BEFORE YOU WRITE: Use the planning frame. Circle the form, audience and purpose, and mark each argument in the text: agree, disagree or “yes, but...”.

Mark scheme • Task 5

Question 1(a) 5 marks

1(a)(i)	Up to 3 marks, e.g.: emotive examples of students who are “ill, bereaved or simply anxious” – invite sympathy; contrast between “years of work” and “an afternoon” – makes the system seem cruel and arbitrary; rhetorical question (“Is it right that a single bad day...?”) – pushes readers to agree; reference to research – adds authority; framing exams as a “ritual” and “a harmful” habit – makes them seem outdated and unthinking.	3
1(a)(ii)	Up to 2 marks, e.g.: partly convincing – it is plausible that parents, tutors and the internet help some students more than others; but it rests on what she has “watched” at one school, and she does not consider that exams also reflect inequality (e.g. paid exam tutoring).	2

Question 1(b) • Reading 10 marks

Mark with the Reading bands on the Marking Guidance page. The top bands need candidates to **evaluate** the ideas in the text, not just repeat them. Indicative content:

For coursework (Text 1). exams test narrow skills – memory, speed, pressure; employers value teamwork, creativity, communication, research; one bad day can undo years of work; anxiety lowers some students’ performance; coursework rewards consistent effort, drafting and real projects; lower stress and deeper learning elsewhere; cheating can be solved by supervision.

For exams (Text 2). equal conditions for everyone; no help from parents, tutors or the internet; coursework hides inequality; exams teach performing under pressure, useful for life; coursework deadlines create year-round stress; exams can be improved (resits, testing more than memory).

Evaluation opportunities (credit highly). unnamed surveys and research in Text 1; the claim that few jobs resemble exams ignores interviews and tests at work (Text 2’s point); a single friend’s story in Text 2; Text 2 relies on personal observation at one school; both writers concede weaknesses in their own position; exams also contain hidden inequality (tutoring); “stress-free paradise” challenges Text 1’s evidence on stress; the common ground suggests a combined system.

Question 1(b) • Writing 25 marks

Mark with the Writing bands. Check the conventions of a article (see the Form Toolkit), register suited to the audience, a clear structure, and accurate, varied sentences and vocabulary.

Model article • Task 5

A top-band response (305 words). Use it after students have tried the task themselves. It shows one strong answer, not the only one.

Pens Down? Why We Need a Smarter Mix

Every June, the school hall fills with rows of desks, and hundreds of us try to squeeze two years of learning into two hours. Our school is now asking whether some of those exams should be replaced with coursework. Two recent pieces – one by an education researcher, one by a sixth-form student – suggest the answer is less obvious than either side claims.

Dr Mansour argues that exams test the wrong things: memory and speed rather than teamwork, creativity and research. It is a persuasive point, but her evidence is vague. We hear about “surveys of businesses” and “research on exam anxiety” without learning who carried them out. Even so, anyone who has watched a friend freeze in an exam will recognise her warning that a single bad day can undo years of work.

Priyanka Nair’s defence of exams rests on fairness, and it is her strongest argument. In an exam hall, nobody’s parents can polish your answers. Coursework, she writes, “does not remove inequality; it hides it”. This rings true, although it is based on what she has seen at one school, and exams have their own unfairness: students whose families can pay for tutors still arrive better prepared.

Interestingly, the two writers agree on more than they admit. Dr Mansour accepts that coursework needs careful supervision; Priyanka accepts that exams should test more than memory and offer quicker resits.

That common ground points to the answer. Our school should keep exams for core knowledge, but add one supervised project in each subject, completed mostly in class, so that teamwork and research count too. Deadlines should be spread sensibly, so coursework never becomes “the exam that never ends”.

The goal is not to abolish pressure, but to measure more of what we can actually do.

Why this scores highly

- Headline and relatable opening suit a school-website audience.
- Questions the quality of evidence on both sides – unnamed research, a single school.
- Turns Text 2’s fairness argument around by noting exams’ own hidden inequality.
- Identifies the concessions each writer makes, then builds a solution from them.
- Concise, confident conclusion that sums up the position in one line.

Text

Reaching for the Stars – or Wasting Them?

Magazine feature

- 1 When a rocket lifts off, the whole world seems to hold its breath. Millions watch the launch live; children press their faces to screens; for a few minutes, the quarrels of our planet seem very small. Yet every launch also raises an uncomfortable question. With so many problems on Earth – hunger, disease, climate change – can we really justify spending billions on space?
- 2 Critics argue that we cannot. The budget of a single major space mission could fund thousands of schools or vaccinate millions of children. A crewed mission to Mars, some estimates suggest, could cost more than many countries spend on healthcare in a decade. ‘We should fix our own house before we build another,’ one campaigner told me. Others point out that the benefits of space technology tend to reach wealthy countries first, while poorer nations bear the heaviest costs of climate change and disease. It is a powerful argument, and it is hard to look at the numbers without some discomfort.
- 3 But the picture is more complicated than it first appears. Space programmes have given us technologies we now take for granted. Satellite systems guide our aeroplanes, ships and phones; weather satellites warn of hurricanes days before they strike, saving countless lives. Research for space missions has contributed to advances in water purification, medical imaging and solar power. Much of the money spent ‘on space’ is in fact spent on Earth, employing scientists, engineers and manufacturers.
- 4 Satellites have also become one of our most important tools for protecting the planet. They measure melting ice, track deforestation and monitor rising seas. It is difficult to understand climate change without them.
- 5 Space is also becoming cheaper. Reusable rockets have cut the cost of launches dramatically, and small, inexpensive satellites built by universities and even schools are now reaching orbit. Several developing countries have launched their own programmes, using satellites to monitor crops, water supplies and natural disasters. For them, space is not a luxury but a practical tool.
- 6 Then there is the question of inspiration, which is harder to measure but no less real. Many of today’s engineers and scientists say they chose their careers because they watched a launch as a child. A country that explores space tells its young people that ambition is possible.
- 7 None of this means that every space project is worth its price. Some missions have gone wildly over budget; others seem driven more by national pride than by scientific curiosity. And the recent rush of private companies into space raises new questions – about who benefits, about the growing clouds of debris circling the Earth – one study estimated that

many thousands of fragments are large enough to damage a working satellite – and about whether space tourism for the very rich is a sensible use of resources at all.

- 8 Perhaps the real question is not whether we should explore space, but how. Spending that brings clear benefits to people on Earth – in communication, in science, in protecting the environment – is surely easier to defend than a race to plant a flag.
- 9 As I watched the most recent launch, surrounded by a crowd of cheering schoolchildren, I found it hard to believe that curiosity is ever entirely wasted. But I also found myself thinking about the children who would never see a rocket, because they had never seen a school.

Paper 2 Section A • Task 6: Is Space Worth It?

Section A • 40 marks • about 1 hour. Read the text in the insert (about 550 words), then answer Question 1(a) and Question 1(b). Suggested timing: read and answer 1(a) 15 min • plan 1(b) 8 min • write 1(b) 35 min • check 2 min.

Question 1(a) 5 marks

- (i) Explain how the writer uses the opening and the ending of the article to influence readers. [3]
- (ii) How convincing is the critics' argument about the cost of space exploration, as it is presented in the text? Give reasons for your answer. [2]

Question 1(b) 35 marks

Your school is holding a debate on the motion: 'This house believes that space exploration is a waste of money.' You have been asked to give a speech. [35]

In your speech you should:

- evaluate the arguments for and against space exploration given in the text
- give your own view, with reasons, on whether the motion is right.

Base your speech on what you have read in the text, but be careful to use your own words.

Address both bullet points. Write about **250 to 350 words**. Up to 10 marks are available for the content of your answer and up to 25 marks for the quality of your writing.

BEFORE YOU WRITE: Use the planning frame. Circle the form, audience and purpose, and mark each argument in the text: agree, disagree or "yes, but...".

Mark scheme • Task 6

Question 1(a) 5 marks

- | | | |
|----------|---|---|
| 1(a)(i) | Up to 3 marks, e.g.: the opening creates wonder with a dramatic image (“the whole world seems to hold its breath”, children at screens) before turning to an “uncomfortable question” – readers are drawn in, then made to think; the ending returns to the launch and cheering children (circular structure), then closes with a poignant contrast – children who “had never seen a school” – leaving readers with a moral tension rather than an easy answer. | 3 |
| <hr/> | | |
| 1(a)(ii) | Up to 2 marks, e.g.: forceful – vivid comparisons with schools and vaccines make the cost feel real; but the figures are vague (“some estimates suggest”), rely on one campaigner’s quote, and ignore the writer’s point that much of the money is spent on Earth. | 2 |

Question 1(b) • Reading 10 marks

Mark with the Reading bands on the Marking Guidance page. The top bands need candidates to **evaluate** the ideas in the text, not just repeat them. Indicative content:

Against spending (critics). urgent problems on Earth – hunger, disease, climate change; one mission could fund thousands of schools or millions of vaccinations; a Mars mission could exceed many countries’ health spending; “fix our own house” first; over-budget missions; national pride; private companies, debris and space tourism for the rich; benefits reach wealthy countries first.

For spending. satellite navigation and communications; weather warnings save lives; spin-offs in water purification, medical imaging, solar power; money creates jobs on Earth; satellites monitor ice, forests and seas – essential to understanding climate change; inspiration for future scientists; reusable rockets and cheap satellites cut costs; developing countries use satellites for crops, water and disasters.

Evaluation opportunities (credit highly). vague estimates; a single campaigner; “countless lives” is not quantified; inspiration is acknowledged to be hard to measure; the writer’s own distinction between useful spending and flag-planting; the emotional ending versus the evidence in the middle; the motion as “all or nothing”; “one study estimated” is unnamed; falling costs weaken the critics’ figures; developing countries’ programmes challenge the idea that space benefits only the rich.

Question 1(b) • Writing 25 marks

Mark with the Writing bands. Check the conventions of a speech (see the Form Toolkit), register suited to the audience, a clear structure, and accurate, varied sentences and vocabulary.

Model speech • Task 6

A top-band response (320 words). Use it after students have tried the task themselves. It shows one strong answer, not the only one.

Madam Chair, members of the opposition, fellow students,

Tonight we are asked to agree that space exploration is a waste of money. I urge you to vote against this motion – not because every rocket is worth its price, but because the motion is far too simple.

Let me begin with the strongest argument on the other side. The cost of a single major mission, we are told, could build thousands of schools or vaccinate millions of children. That comparison should make all of us uncomfortable. But notice where the figures come from: “some estimates suggest”. We are not told whose estimates, or how they were calculated. And the comparison assumes that money spent on space simply vanishes. It does not. Much of it pays scientists, engineers and factory workers here on Earth.

Now consider what that spending has given us. The phone in your pocket depends on satellites. Weather satellites warn coastal towns days before a hurricane arrives. And without satellites measuring melting ice and shrinking forests, we would understand far less about climate change – one of the very problems the critics say we should be solving instead.

I will admit that the other side has a point about some projects. Missions that run wildly over budget, or races driven by national pride, are hard to defend. And I share the writer’s doubts about space tourism for the very rich.

But that is an argument for spending wisely, not for giving up. The right question is not “Should we explore space?” but “Which missions help people on Earth?”

The article ends with children who have never seen a school. We should build those schools. But we should also remember the children who watched a launch and decided to become engineers. A world that stops exploring will not solve its problems faster; it will simply have fewer people with the ambition to try.

Vote against the motion. Thank you.

Why this scores highly

- Formal debate conventions: address to the chair and audience, a clear stance, a direct call to vote.
- Tackles the opposing case first and questions its evidence (“some estimates suggest”).
- Turns the critics’ own concern – climate change – into support for satellites.
- Concedes weaker projects, which makes the overall argument more credible.
- Reframes the question and echoes the article’s ending for a powerful close.

Text 1

Don't Drive Customers Away

Letter to a local newspaper

- 1 Sir, I read with alarm that the council plans to ban cars from the old town centre from next spring. As the owner of a hardware shop that has traded on Market Street for thirty-four years, I can tell you exactly what will happen: customers will go elsewhere.
- 2 Many of my customers are elderly, or tradespeople who need to load heavy goods such as paint, timber and tools. They cannot carry a bag of cement to a bus stop. When the council closed Bridge Street for roadworks last year, my takings fell by nearly a third in a single month. Several shops on that street never recovered.
- 3 The council talks about 'vibrant pedestrian spaces' and 'café culture'. That is all very well for people with time to sit and drink coffee. But a town centre is not a theme park. It is a place where people need to get things done. If they cannot park near the shops, they will drive to the out-of-town retail park, where parking is free and plentiful, and the old centre will slowly die. Parking fees in the centre are already the highest in the region.
- 4 I have also spoken to my neighbours on Market Street. The bakery, the pharmacy and the shoe repairer all share my fears. Not one of us was consulted before the plan was announced.
- 5 Nobody is against clean air. But the council should improve buses and add cycle lanes without punishing the businesses that have kept this town alive for generations. I urge readers to attend the public meeting on the 12th and make their voices heard.
- 6 Yours faithfully,
George Pappas, Pappas Hardware, Market Street

Text 2

Give Our Streets Back to People

Blog post by a local parent

- 1 Every morning I walk my two children to school through the old town, and every morning I hold their hands a little too tightly. Cars queue bumper to bumper along streets that were built for horses and carts. Delivery vans mount the pavements. Last month, a van reversing onto the pavement missed my daughter by inches. The air smells of exhaust, and my younger son, who has asthma, coughs his way to the school gate.
- 2 So I was delighted to hear that the council plans to make the centre car-free. Towns that have done this have seen remarkable results. In one city I visited last summer, the main square had been transformed from a car park into a place full of market stalls, street musicians and children playing. Shopkeepers there told me that business had never been better, because people who walk linger, browse and come back.
- 3 It is understandable that some shop owners are worried. Change is frightening, and nobody wants to see a family business struggle. But the evidence from many places suggests that pedestrians spend more over a month than drivers do, because they visit more often. A council survey of residents found that most people supported the idea, although I accept that shop owners were less keen. And the council's plan includes loading hours for deliveries, disabled parking at the edges of the zone and a free shuttle bus from the car parks.
- 4 Our old town is beautiful, but at the moment you would hardly notice, because you are too busy dodging traffic. Imagine hearing footsteps and conversation instead of engines. Imagine letting your children walk ahead of you without fear.
- 5 The streets belong to all of us. It is time we gave them back to people.

Paper 2 Section A · Task 7: A Car-Free Town Centre

Section A · 40 marks · about 1 hour. Read both texts in the insert (about 560 words), then answer Question 1(a) and Question 1(b). Suggested timing: read and answer 1(a) 15 min · plan 1(b) 8 min · write 1(b) 35 min · check 2 min.

Question 1(a) 5 marks

- (i) Explain how the writer of Text 2 uses personal experience to influence readers. Refer to **two** examples from the text. [3]
- (ii) How convincing is the evidence in Text 1 about the Bridge Street roadworks? Give reasons for your answer. [2]

Question 1(b) 35 marks

The local newspaper has invited readers to send letters about the council's plan to make the old town centre car-free. [35]

In your letter you should:

- evaluate the arguments for and against the plan given in both texts
- give your own view, with reasons, on what the council should do.

Base your letter on what you have read in both texts, but be careful to use your own words.

Address both bullet points. Write about **250 to 350 words**. Up to 10 marks are available for the content of your answer and up to 25 marks for the quality of your writing.

BEFORE YOU WRITE: Use the planning frame. Circle the form, audience and purpose, and mark each argument in the text: agree, disagree or "yes, but...".

Mark scheme • Task 7

Question 1(a) 5 marks

1(a)(i)	Up to 3 marks, e.g.: the daily walk with her children (“hold their hands a little too tightly”) creates fear and protectiveness readers share; her son’s asthma (“coughs his way to the school gate”) is emotive and makes pollution personal; the city she visited offers a vivid, hopeful picture (market stalls, musicians, children playing); “Imagine...” invites readers into her vision.	3
1(a)(ii)	Up to 2 marks, e.g.: specific and local (“nearly a third in a single month”), so it seems persuasive; but roadworks are disruptive and temporary, with none of the loading hours, disabled parking or shuttle bus in the council’s plan, so it is not a fair comparison; “several shops... never recovered” is vague.	2

Question 1(b) • Reading 10 marks

Mark with the Reading bands on the Marking Guidance page. The top bands need candidates to **evaluate** the ideas in the text, not just repeat them. Indicative content:

Against the plan (Text 1). customers will go elsewhere; elderly customers and tradespeople need to load heavy goods; takings fell by a third during the Bridge Street roadworks; some shops never recovered; “café culture” suits people with spare time, not practical shopping; drivers will switch to the free-parking retail park; improve buses and cycle lanes instead; neighbouring shops share his fears; businesses were not consulted; parking fees are already high.

For the plan (Text 2). traffic, vans on pavements and exhaust make walking dangerous and unhealthy; asthma; another city transformed its square and business improved; pedestrians visit more often and spend more over a month; the plan includes loading hours, disabled parking and a free shuttle; a quieter, more beautiful centre; a near-miss with a van; most residents supported the idea in a council survey.

Evaluation opportunities (credit highly). roadworks are not the same as a planned car-free zone; single-city holiday evidence and “shopkeepers told me”; “evidence from many places” is unnamed; Text 1 ignores the plan’s loading and shuttle arrangements; Text 2 underplays the needs of trade customers; the council survey shows support but also that shop owners disagree – whose views count most?; lack of consultation is a fair criticism of process, not of the idea itself; both accept clean air matters – room for a compromise or trial.

Question 1(b) • Writing 25 marks

Mark with the Writing bands. Check the conventions of a letter (see the Form Toolkit), register suited to the audience, a clear structure, and accurate, varied sentences and vocabulary.

Model letter • Task 7

A top-band response (279 words). Use it after students have tried the task themselves. It shows one strong answer, not the only one.

Dear Editor,

I am writing in response to recent views on the council's plan to make the old town centre car-free. I support the plan, but I believe the council must listen carefully to local businesses and introduce it in stages.

Mr Pappas's concerns deserve to be taken seriously. His hardware shop has served this town for thirty-four years, and customers who need cement or timber cannot simply hop on a bus. However, his main evidence – the fall in takings when Bridge Street was closed for roadworks – is not a fair comparison. Roadworks are noisy and disruptive, with no alternative arrangements. The council's plan, by contrast, includes loading hours, disabled parking and a free shuttle from the car parks, details his letter does not mention.

The case for change is strong. Anyone who has walked along Market Street at eight in the morning will recognise the scene described by a local parent online: queuing traffic, vans on the pavements and children breathing exhaust fumes. Her claim that pedestrians spend more than drivers is encouraging, although her evidence comes largely from one city she visited on holiday, so we should be cautious about assuming the same will happen here.

I would therefore urge the council to begin with a one-year trial, perhaps at weekends first, and to measure visitor numbers and shop takings carefully. Businesses such as Pappas Hardware should be given free loading bays and help to set up home deliveries, so that heavy goods can still reach customers.

Our old town is too beautiful to be a traffic jam, and too precious to lose its shops. With care, we can protect both.

Yours faithfully,
Aisha Karimi

Why this scores highly

- Correct letter conventions for a newspaper: "Dear Editor", clear purpose, "Yours faithfully".
- Respects the opposing writer while exposing the weakness of his roadworks comparison.
- Uses details from Text 2 to answer concerns that Text 1 leaves out.
- Cautious evaluation of Text 2's holiday evidence shows balance.
- Practical, original proposal (a measured trial) and a balanced, memorable close.

Text

Should Teenagers Work? Survey Sparks Debate

Newspaper report

- 1 A new survey suggesting that fewer teenagers than ever have part-time jobs has sparked a lively debate among parents, teachers and employers.
- 2 The survey, carried out by a youth employment charity, questioned 1,200 students aged 15 to 18 and found that just one in five had worked for money in the past year, compared with almost half of young people a generation ago. The charity's director, Hannah Brooks, described the trend as 'worrying'. 'A Saturday job teaches things no classroom can,' she said. 'Turning up on time, dealing with customers, handling money, being part of a team. Employers tell us that young people who have worked are far more confident at interview.' Last year the charity helped more than 3,000 young people into their first jobs.
- 3 Some students agree. Seventeen-year-old Omar Hussein, who works eight hours a week at a supermarket, said the job had changed him. 'I used to be really shy. Now I talk to hundreds of people every weekend. I'm saving for driving lessons, so I appreciate money more because I've earned it. My grades have actually gone up, because I've learned to organise my time.' His manager, he added, always lets him swap shifts when he has exams.
- 4 But others fear that work takes time away from study. Deputy head teacher Ruth Adeyemi said she had seen students 'exhausted on Monday mornings' after long weekend shifts. 'At sixteen, your main job is your education,' she said. 'A few hours can be fine, but some students are working twenty hours a week, and their grades suffer.' She added that exam years were particularly demanding.
- 5 The survey itself found a mixed picture. Students who worked fewer than ten hours a week reported similar grades to those who did not work, while those who worked more than fifteen hours were more likely to report falling behind. Around a third of students without jobs said they would like one but could not find any, particularly in rural areas and small towns. The survey did not ask about family income, and critics pointed out that some teenagers work because their families need the money, not to build skills.
- 6 Some employers said they were reluctant to hire under-18s because of paperwork and limits on working hours. 'It's often easier to hire a university student,' said the manager of a local café, who asked not to be named.
- 7 Parents at a school meeting in the town last week were divided. 'My daughter's job has made her far more responsible,' said one mother. Another parent said that her son's employer had repeatedly asked him to work late on school nights. 'He felt he couldn't say no,' she said. A father said that his son had used his wages to buy his own laptop for school.

- 8 Teachers at the meeting also raised concerns about safety. Several said that students working late shifts often travelled home alone after dark, and that some workplaces, such as busy kitchens, carried a real risk of injury for inexperienced staff.
- 9 Employment law restricts the hours and types of work that younger teenagers can do, but campaigners say the rules are not always followed. The charity is calling for schools to help students find suitable, well-supervised jobs and to teach them about their rights at work.
- 10 Ms Brooks said the aim was balance. ‘Nobody wants teenagers working instead of studying,’ she said. ‘But a few hours a week can build skills that last a lifetime.’

Paper 2 Section A · Task 8: Teenagers and Part-Time Work

Section A · 40 marks · about 1 hour. Read the text in the insert (about 560 words), then answer Question 1(a) and Question 1(b). Suggested timing: read and answer 1(a) 15 min · plan 1(b) 8 min · write 1(b) 35 min · check 2 min.

Question 1(a) 5 marks

- (i) Explain how the charity director, Hannah Brooks, tries to persuade people that part-time jobs are valuable. Refer to **two** examples from the text. [3]
- (ii) How reliable is the survey evidence about part-time work and grades? Give reasons for your answer. [2]

Question 1(b) 35 marks

Your school's careers department has asked you to write a report for parents on whether students should be encouraged to take part-time jobs. [35]

In your report you should:

- evaluate the arguments and evidence in the text
- recommend, with reasons, what advice the school should give to students and parents.

Base your report on what you have read in the text, but be careful to use your own words.

Address both bullet points. Write about **250 to 350 words**. Up to 10 marks are available for the content of your answer and up to 25 marks for the quality of your writing.

BEFORE YOU WRITE: Use the planning frame. Circle the form, audience and purpose, and mark each argument in the text: agree, disagree or "yes, but..."

Mark scheme · Task 8

Question 1(a) 5 marks

- | | | |
|-----------------|---|----------|
| 1(a)(i) | Up to 3 marks, e.g.: a bold claim (“teaches things no classroom can”) that sets work above school in one respect; a list of practical skills (punctuality, customers, money, teamwork) that sounds concrete and useful; appeal to authority (“Employers tell us...”); describing the trend as “worrying” to create concern; a reasonable, balanced close (“Nobody wants teenagers working instead of studying”) and a memorable phrase (“skills that last a lifetime”). | 3 |
| 1(a)(ii) | Up to 2 marks, e.g.: partly reliable – a large sample of 1,200; but grades were self-reported, not checked; it was carried out by a charity that promotes youth employment, so it may be biased; it did not ask about family income, so other factors may explain the results. | 2 |

Question 1(b) · Reading 10 marks

Mark with the Reading bands on the Marking Guidance page. The top bands need candidates to **evaluate** the ideas in the text, not just repeat them. Indicative content:

Benefits. punctuality, customer service, handling money, teamwork; confidence at interview (according to employers); Omar’s growth from shyness; appreciating earned money; saving for goals; better time management; responsibility (a parent’s view); a flexible manager; buying a laptop for school.

Risks. exhaustion after long shifts; some students working twenty hours; exam years especially demanding; over fifteen hours linked with falling behind; pressure from employers to work late on school nights; rules not always followed; travelling home alone after dark; injury risk in kitchens.

Context. only one in five now work, down from almost half; a third want jobs but can’t find them, especially in rural areas; employers reluctant to hire under-18s; some teenagers work because their families need the money; the charity calls for schools to help find supervised jobs and teach rights.

Evaluation opportunities (credit highly). charity’s possible bias (it places young people in jobs); self-reported grades; “Employers tell us” is unspecific; Omar is a single case; anonymous café manager; the survey ignores family income; under ten hours showed no effect on grades – a useful basis for a recommendation.

Question 1(b) · Writing 25 marks

Mark with the Writing bands. Check the conventions of a report (see the Form Toolkit), register suited to the audience, a clear structure, and accurate, varied sentences and vocabulary.

Model report • Task 8

A top-band response (273 words). Use it after students have tried the task themselves. It shows one strong answer, not the only one.

Report for Parents: Should Students Be Encouraged to Take Part-Time Jobs?

From: Student representative, Careers Department

Purpose

This report evaluates recent evidence about teenagers and part-time work and recommends the advice our school should give.

The benefits

Part-time work can build valuable skills. Hannah Brooks of a youth employment charity lists punctuality, customer service, handling money and teamwork, and one student, Omar Hussein, describes moving from shyness to talking with hundreds of customers each weekend. Earning money can also teach students to value it.

The risks

Work can harm study when hours are long. A deputy head teacher reports students arriving exhausted after weekend shifts, and the survey found that those working more than fifteen hours a week were more likely to fall behind. Some employers also pressure young staff to work late on school nights.

Weaknesses in the evidence

The findings should be treated with caution. The survey was carried out by a charity that promotes youth employment, and grades were reported by students rather than checked. It also did not ask about family income, so it cannot show how many students work out of necessity.

Recommendations

1. Encourage part-time work of up to ten hours a week, the level at which the survey found no effect on grades.
2. Advise students in exam years to reduce their hours from January.
3. Teach all students about their rights at work, including refusing late shifts on school nights.
4. Share a list of suitable, well-supervised local employers, especially for students who want jobs but cannot find them.

Conclusion

A small amount of work can build confidence and skills that last, provided education remains every student's main job.

Why this scores highly

- Full report conventions: title, sender, purpose, subheadings, numbered recommendations, conclusion.
- Neutral, objective register suited to parents and a school department.
- A dedicated section evaluating the reliability and possible bias of the evidence.
- Recommendations draw precisely on the data (the ten-hour threshold).
- Balances benefits and risks before reaching a practical, clearly argued conclusion.

Marking guidance · Question 1(b)

These bands are written for this pack to support consistent practice marking. They follow the published assessment objectives but are not official Cambridge descriptors. Choose the band that best fits, then the mark within it.

Reading 10 marks

9–10	Thorough, perceptive evaluation of ideas from the text(s); evidence questioned and weighed; ideas developed and combined into a convincing argument.
7–8	Clear evaluation of several ideas; a range of ideas used and developed with purpose.
5–6	A range of relevant ideas used, some development; evaluation is occasional or simple.
3–4	Some relevant ideas, mostly repeated rather than developed; little or no evaluation.
1–2	Limited use of the text(s); may copy or misunderstand.

Writing 25 marks

22–25	Highly effective style and register for the audience; confident command of the form; well-structured, persuasive argument; wide, precise vocabulary; varied sentences; very accurate.
17–21	Effective style and appropriate register; secure form; clear, logical structure; good vocabulary; mostly accurate.
12–16	Generally appropriate style; some awareness of form and audience; ideas mostly organised; some errors that do not impede meaning.
7–11	Simple style; inconsistent register; limited structure; errors sometimes distract.
1–6	Little sense of form or audience; weak organisation; frequent errors that impede meaning.

QUICK CHECK: An answer that only repeats the text rarely scores above 6 for Reading, however well it is written. Look for the words “however”, “but”, “this suggests” and “this overlooks”. They usually mark where the evaluation is.

Score tracker

Part	Max	Task 5	Task 6	Task 7	Task 8
1(a) Analysis & evaluation	5				
1(b) Reading	10				
1(b) Writing	25				
Total	40				

If your lowest score is...

1(a)	Name the technique or claim, quote briefly, then say how it affects the reader or whether it convinces you.
1(b) Reading	You are probably repeating. Add a “yes, but...” to every idea you use, and question at least two pieces of evidence.
1(b) Writing	Check the form toolkit. Match your register to the audience, plan four or five paragraphs, and save three minutes to proofread.

NEXT STEP

Complete your 0500 preparation

IGCSE 0500 Complete Exam Guide (2027): the method for every question on both papers, with model answers, timing plans and the top 10 mark-losing mistakes.

IGCSE 0500 Paper 1 Practice Packs 1 & 2 (2027): six full Paper 1 Reading practice papers with original texts and detailed mark schemes.

Paper 2 Directed Writing comes in two volumes: Tasks 1–4 and Tasks 5–8.

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